

Musical Vocabulary (concepts) to be learned: motive, theme, programmatic music, idee fixe

Grade Level: Grade 8 General Music

Note: This lesson is adaptable for younger and older students, and it could be use as an enhancement lesson with a performance based class (e.g. band, choir, or orchestra). Teaching this lesson would take place in 1 meeting of the class.

Objective:

Given a demonstration, discussion, and practice using the musical concepts of **idée fixe** and programmatic music, the student will demonstrate the ability to define what **idée fixe** is and recognize its use by analyzing how a recurring theme evolves in response to narrative or emotional shifts in a musical excerpt, identifying its variations and connections to the story on a written, listening-based quiz administered in-class at the end of the unit.

Equipment & Resources:

Stereo/Sound system Recording of musical piece: *Symphonie Fantastique* by Hector Berlioz
Simplified notes/summary on the plot of *Symphonie Fantastique*
(The written quiz will be administered at the end of the unit.)

Anticipatory Set:

T. plays an intriguing excerpt from the opening of *Symphonie Fantastique first movement Reveries - Passions* and asks students:

- How does this music make you feel?
- What story or scene could this music be suggesting?

Introduction of the subject to be learned (optional):

"In the next few classes we spend together, we're going to be exploring some more new musical concepts: Motive, Theme, Programmatic Music and idee fixe. But first I'm going to introduce you to a story."

Lecture/Demonstration:

T. Summarizes the plot in the beginning of Berlioz's *Symphonie Fantastique*, focusing on introducing and portraying the characteristics of the lovesick artist and his beloved.

T. introduces to students the concepts of *idée fixe* and programmatic music and asks students to suggest and brainstorm ways that music might be composed to tell this story.

- What kind of music, tempo, timbre, or instruments might be used to portray the lovesick artist?
- What kind of music, tempo, timbre, or instruments might be used to portray his beloved girl?

Ss. suggestions are recorded on the chalkboard.

Definitions:

- Motive – a short musical idea, melodic, harmonic, or rhythmic, or all three. It is the shortest version of a phrase or Theme that maintains its identity throughout a piece of music.
- Theme – a recognizable melody on which all or part of a piece of music is based. Themes are different from Motives in that they are melodies (i.e., they have both pitch and rhythmic characteristics), and they are usually longer, more complete musical ideas.
- An ***idée fixe*** is a recurring musical theme that represents a specific idea, character, or emotion, often evolving throughout a composition to reflect changes in the narrative or mood.
- Programmatic music – Music of a narrative or descriptive kind. It is distinguished by its purpose, which is to depict objects and events or, in some cases, to tell a story.

Modeling

T. introduces how Berlioz utilizes compositional devices to portray the characters (and musical devices to set the scene) and then plays the theme of the beloved (in movement one). Compare the similarities and differences between what Ss suggested and the actual theme.

T. plays recordings of excerpts of the *first movement of Symphonie Fantastique*, providing students with opportunities and cues to grasp how Berlioz set the story musically.

T. then plays excerpts from:

- *Movement IV - March to the Scaffold* (*idée fixe* is cut short, ominous)
- *Movement V - Dream of a Witches' Sabbath* (distorted and grotesque)

T. explain how the melody changes: “The excerpts are based on the same musical material but now it sounds eerie and twisted. That’s Berlioz showing how the artist’s emotions and view of his beloved change.”

Ss. brainstorm about how they think the story concludes based on how the *idée fixe* has changed (explain with reasons for their ideas).

T. tells the students how the story actually ends and what Berlioz did to portray this ending musically. T and Ss listen to the excerpt again to validate the class's conclusion (and the story's) conclusion.

Closure:

T. asks students if they have any other examples of programmatic music that tells a story.

T. explains that there are many others and that some will be introduced in future lessons.

T. plays *Symphonie Fantastique* in its entirety.

Assessment:

Note: This is one lesson in a larger, Multi-Unit Plan focusing on Musical Form. A twenty-item quiz will be administered at the end of the full unit.

By the end of the class, the student will be asked to complete a written exam testing their knowledge on the concept of

(1) to identify in writing the definitions of the terms motive, theme, and idee fixe?

(2) to explain, using terms learned in class, how programmatic music serves to depict objects or events or to tell a story.

Quiz

Part 1: Definitions (25 points)

1. (5 points) Define the term **motive**
2. (5 points) Define the term **theme**
3. (5 points) Define the term **programmatic music**
4. (5 points) Define **idée fixe** in your own words.
5. (5 points) Explain how an idée fixe is used in *Symphonie Fantastique*.

Part 2: Listening Analysis (20 points)

(Play excerpts from *Symphonie Fantastique* during the quiz.)

For each excerpt, answer the following questions:

1. Excerpt A (*Movement I – Reveries, Passions*)
 - a. (3 points) What mood or emotion does the idée fixe convey in this movement?
 - b. (3 points) Why do you think the composer made it sound this way?
2. Excerpt B (*Movement IV – March to the Scaffold*)
 - a. (3 points) How has the idée fixe changed in this movement?
 - b. (3 points) What does this change tell us about the story or the artist's emotions?
3. Excerpt C (*Movement V – Dream of a Witches' Sabbath*)
 - a. (3 points) Describe the idée fixe in this movement. How does it sound different from earlier?
 - b. (3 points) What does this version of the idée fixe represent?

Part 3: Application and Reflection (10 points)

1. (5 points) Imagine you are writing a piece of music about your favorite story or movie. Describe the character or idea you would represent with an idée fixe.
2. (5 points) How would your idée fixe change to show different emotions or events in your story?

Bonus Question (5 points)

Why do you think Berlioz chose to use the idée fixe instead of creating new melodies for each part of the story?

Total Points: 55 points (+5 for bonus)